

Paul Fein

With Carlos Alcaraz undefeated 4-0 in Grand Slam finals and Jannik Sinner 3-0, the boxing catchphrase — ‘Somebody’s 0 has to go’ — applied to the young heavyweight titans of tennis before their eagerly

anticipated clash. That was just one of the dynamic elements that would make their spectacular 4-6, 6-7 (4), 6-4, 7-6 (3), 7-6 (2) duel the greatest ever at Roland Garros.

Staged at a Grand Slam event — where old reputations hang in the balance and new legends are born — the encounter was a battle between contrasting playing styles and personalities — the go-for-broke and entertaining shot-making of the charismatic Spaniard versus the relentless power of the poker-faced Italian. Although Alcaraz had won their last four matches and led their rivalry 7-4, Sinner had captured the previous two Majors, ranked No. 1 for 50 straight weeks, and hadn’t dropped a set on the *terre battue* in six matches, including a semifinal win over Novak Djokovic, the sport’s GOAT.

The 124th edition of Roland Garros began with a poignant ceremony honouring Rafael Nadal before 10,000 cheering fans, many wearing orange T-shirts with ‘*Merci*’ emblazoned on them. Complementing the eye-catching 10-foot, stainless steel statue of the King of Clay were Nadal’s footprint and the iconic ‘14’ etched on the red clay of Court Chatrier. Players talented enough to compete on the marquee court can now find inspiration from Rafa’s 14 French Open singles titles, a record that will surely never be broken.

Alcaraz, who, as a boy, idolised the Spanish legend, said, “Rafa has destroyed all the records here.” With two RG titles and five overall at age 22, might this brilliant, dedicated athlete who excels on all surfaces someday challenge Nadal’s 22 Grand Slam titles? After all, in the short term anyway, Alcaraz will likely have only one superstar rival to contend with, not two as the legendary Big Three had. Further, the gap between the new Big Two and the field keeps growing as Alcaraz and Sinner keep improving. In a nutshell, Alcaraz has become more consistent, and Sinner more versatile. They’ve divvied up the last six Grand Slam titles since Djokovic, now 38, claimed his 24th and last one at the 2023 US Open. And during these 15 days in Paris, no opponent seriously threatened either superstar.

Musetti no match for Alcaraz

Alcaraz, prone to occasional lapses in concentration and consistency, dropped sets in four-set victories over Fabian Marozsan, Damir Dzumhur, and 13th seed Ben Shelton before crushing Tommy Paul. The Spanish magician has produced plenty of astounding shots in his young career, but a winner against Shelton was too amazing to be true. Lunging for a backhand volley out of his reach for Shelton’s passing shot, Alcaraz threw his racket, which contacted the ball and propelled it just over the net for a fluke winner. Alcaraz honourably informed the umpire what happened — which violated the rules — and she awarded the point to Shelton, giving the American a break point. He also called a serve ‘in’ that the linesperson had erroneously called otherwise, again resulting in a changed call favouring his opponent. These gestures earned Alcaraz the tournament sportsmanship award in my book.

In the semifinals, Alcaraz faced Musetti, whom he had decisively defeated in their last

IF THERE HAD BEEN ANY LINGERING DOUBTS ABOUT THEIR TOTAL DOMINATION, THE NEW BIG TWO EMPHATICALLY DISPELLED THEM. THIS GRAND SLAM FINAL WOULD BE THEIR FIRST AGAINST EACH OTHER, AND IT PROVED TO BE HISTORIC